

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 71 OF 102

Ouk Chaktrang (Cambodian Chess)

8×8

BOARD

2

PLAYERS

OUK CHAKTRANG (CAMBODIAN CHESS)

Ouk Chaktrang is the traditional chess of Cambodia. It belongs to the Makruk family — the Southeast Asian branch of chess descended from Indian Chaturanga — and is the closest living relative of the medieval game that spread from India across Asia. Modern rules are codified by the Asian Chess Federation and the Cambodian Chess Federation.

PIECES

KHMER NAME	PIECE	MOVEMENT
Sdech (ស៊េច)	King	1 square in any direction. Special first move: if the King has not yet moved, it may instead jump as a Knight (once only, provided the King is not in check).
Neang/Met (នាង)	Queen	1 square diagonally, OR 1 square straight forward.
Koul (គោល)	Bishop	1 square diagonally, OR leaps exactly 2 squares diagonally (can jump over an intervening piece).
Ses (សេះ)	Knight	Standard L-shape: 2 squares orthogonally then 1 square perpendicularly. Jumps over intervening pieces.
Touk (ត្រីក)	Rook	Slides any number of squares orthogonally.
Trey (ត្រី)	Pawn	Moves 1 square straight forward. Captures 1 square diagonally forward. No double first move. Promotes on reaching rank 6.

STARTING POSITION

Identical to Makruk. Pawns begin on ranks 3 (White) and 6 (Black), not rank 2/7.

8								
7	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	
6								
5	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	
4	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	
3								
2	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	
1								
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h

Neang (Queen) begins beside the Sdech (King): White's Neang on d1 (to King's left from White's perspective), Black's Neang on e8.

PAWN PROMOTION

A Trey reaching rank 6 (for White) or rank 3 (for Black) promotes immediately to a Neang. There is no choice — promotion to Neang is the only option.

KING'S FIRST MOVE

On the Sdech's very first move of the game, if it has not previously moved, the player may instead move the King as a Knight (the standard L-shape jump). This privilege is lost permanently after the King moves or after the King is in check.

KOUL MOVEMENT DETAIL

The Koul (Bishop) may move either:

- ♦ 1 square diagonally (standard ferz-style step), OR
- ♦ Exactly 2 squares diagonally, leaping over any piece on the intermediate square.

It cannot slide any further — it is not a long-range diagonal slider like the FIDE Bishop.

CHECK AND CHECKMATE

A player whose King is in check must resolve the check on the next move. Checkmate — where the King is in check and no legal move resolves it — ends the game; the checkmated player loses.

STALEMATE

Stalemate (player has no legal move but is not in check) is a loss for the stalemated player, not a draw.

COUNTING RULES (DRAW MECHANISM)

When one player has no remaining Pawns, the opponent must deliver checkmate within a set number of moves or the game is drawn:

OPPONENT'S DOMINANT PIECE	MOVES ALLOWED
Rooks only	8 moves
Bishops and/or Knights only	16 moves
Neang only	22 moves

The count begins the moment the last Pawn is captured. If the count expires without checkmate, the game is drawn. The count resets if a piece is captured during the countdown.

DIFFERENCES FROM MAKRUK

FEATURE	MAKRUK (THAI)	OUK CHAKTRANG (CAMBODIAN)
Koul/Bishop	1 step diagonally only	1 step or 2-square diagonal leap
King's first move	No special rule	May jump as Knight once
Counting rules	Makruk counting system	Streamlined system above

ATTRIBUTION

Traditional Cambodian game. Modern competitive rules codified by the Asian Chess Federation. Fully public domain.